

Married but lonely: An examination of gender within married religious students



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INTRODUCTION

The purpose of this study is to examine gender differences in loneliness and social media use among young married adults attending religious universities. We address whether marriage provides equal social benefits for men and women. Marriage is often linked to better physical health, yet these benefits depend on the quality of the relationship (Reyes et al., 2025). Additionally, religiosity and spirituality are generally associated with better mental health, offering modest stress-buffering benefits (Lucchetti et al., 2021). Higher marital satisfaction is consistently associated with better physical and mental health, whereas conflict or low-quality marriages are associated with weaker or even negative effects (Robles et al., 2014).



Research Question

Do religiously affiliated married men and women attending college report differences in affect and social well-being?

METHOD

Procedure

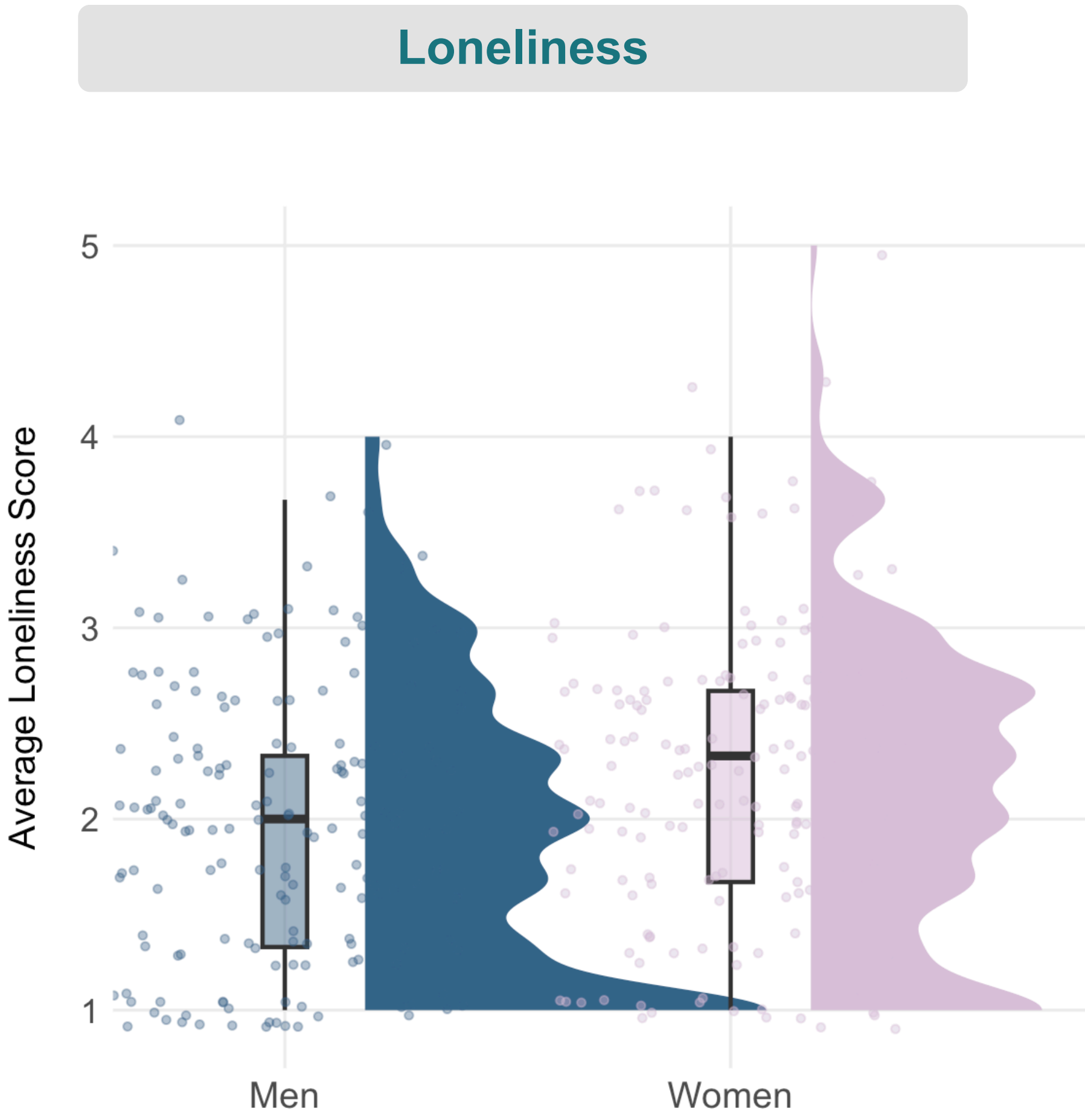
In a between-subjects design, participants were divided into male and female groups. Both groups were given a survey asking about their lives as married couples.

Demographics	
Sample Size	N = 356
Sex	Men = 170, Women = 186
Age	18–30 years, M = 23.26 (SD = 1.86)
Ethnicity	White (84.59%)
Years Married	0–5 years M = 14.11 months (SD = .99)
Job Status	Part-time (64.43%)
Number of Children	No children (88%)

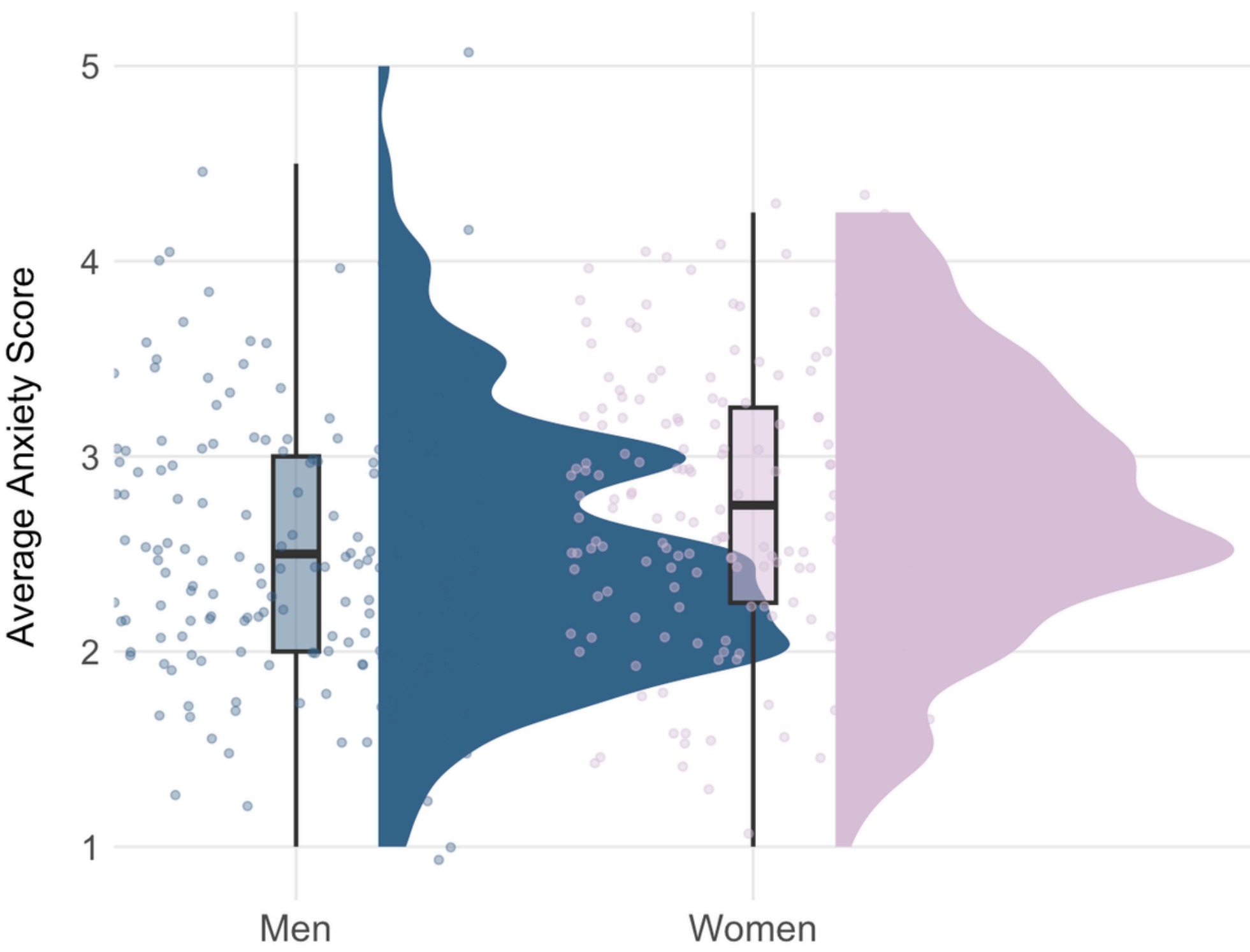
RESULTS

Table 1: Comparison of Men and Women

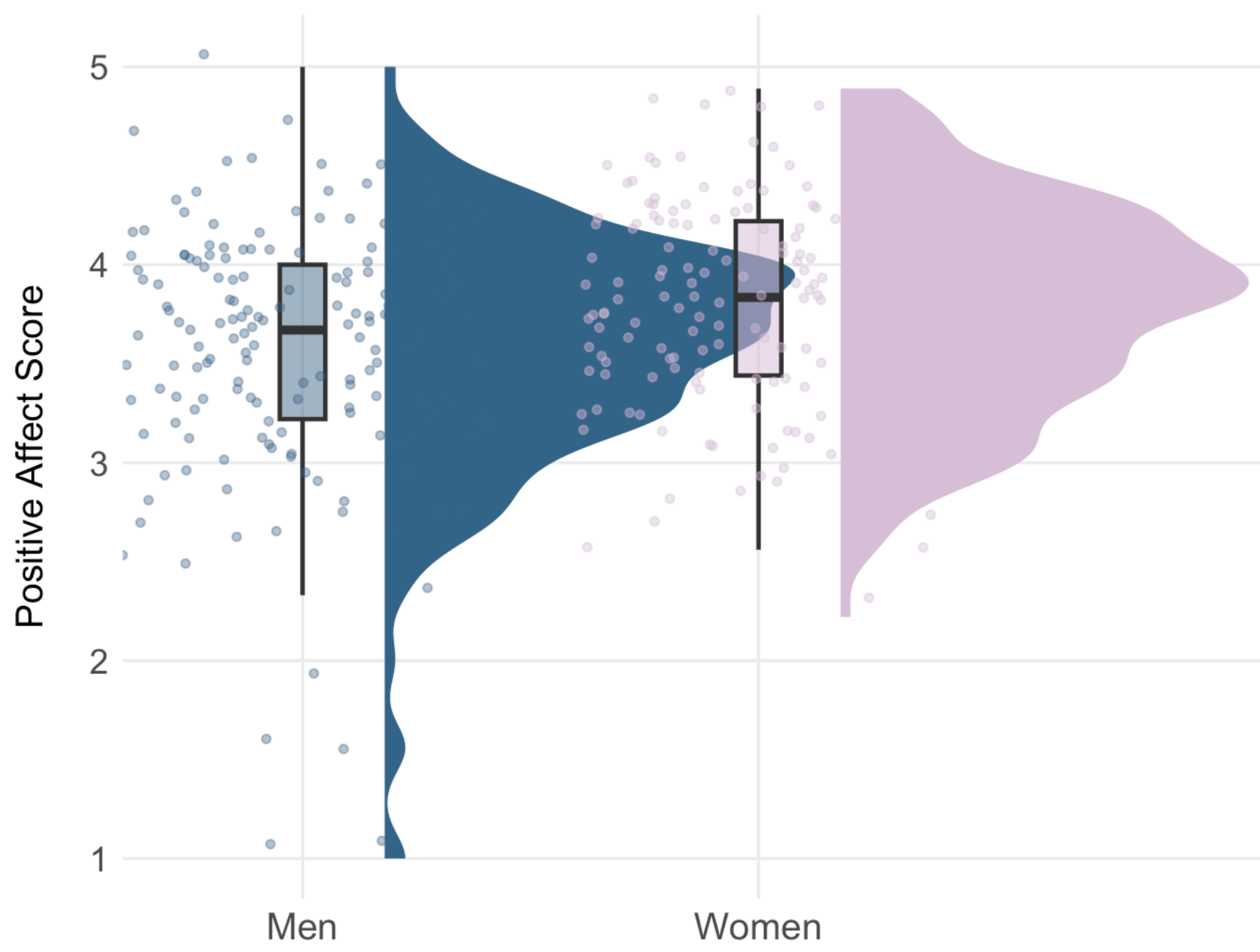
	Men M(SD)	Women M(SD)	Δ	$t(df)$	p	d
Positive Affect	3.570(.625)	3.783(.535)	-.213	-3.445(336)***	<.001	.367
Negative Affect	2.007(.556)	2.123(.556)	-.116	-1.967(352.4)*	.025	.208
Interpersonal Conflict	1.890(.706)	1.719(.627)	+.171	2.412(341)**	.008	.257
Loneliness	2.002(.726)	2.253(.781)	-.251	-3.150(355)**	.009	.333
Anxiety	2.500(.688)	2.774(.707)	-.274	-3.706(352.6)***	<.001	.393
Depressive Symptoms	7.129(2.318)	8.081(2.645)	-.952	-3.624(354.2)***	<.001	.382
Life Satisfaction	5.514(1.058)	5.756(.963)	-.242	-2.249(342.4)*	.013	.240
Social Media Time	115.6(126.7)	132.3(136.9)	-16.7	-1.202(355)	.115	.127



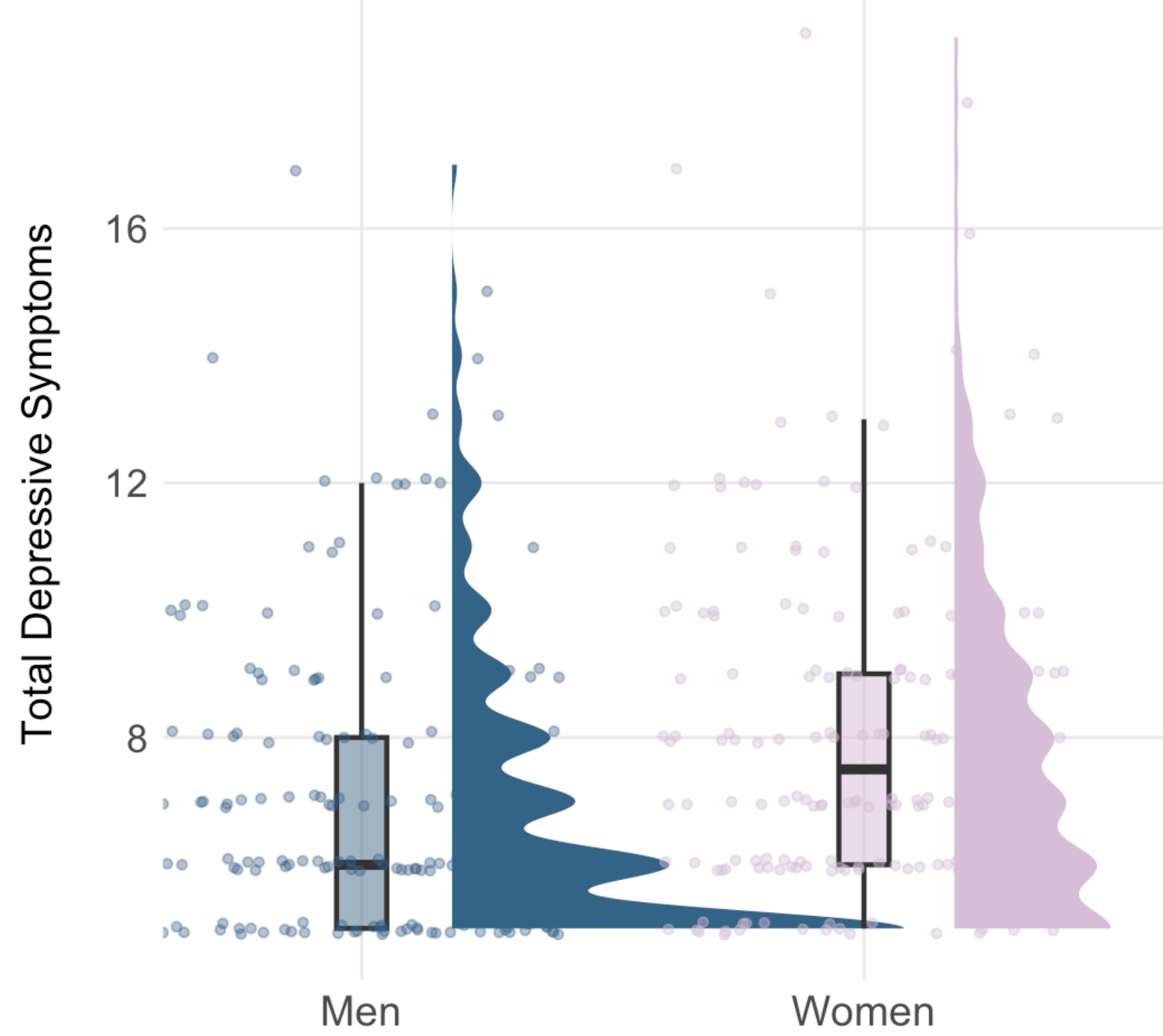
Anxiety



Positive Affect



Depressive Symptoms



DISCUSSION

These findings may suggest religious married women:

- Experience greater emotional intensity than religious married men
- Manifest greater mental health challenges than men, which may be tied to early marital expectations within religious contexts
- Desire greater relational connection and companionship beyond what marital relationships offer, at least at early stages
- May experience higher levels of loneliness due to their perception of bearing greater responsibility for emotional closeness

Future research could include:

- Following couples over time to assess whether these gender differences persist or change after graduation
- Comparing religious and non-religious university samples
- A more focused study regarding the emotional characteristics of married male students
- Exploring how differences in partners' preferred screen activities influence the association between total screen time and marital satisfaction



Scan for References